

Postpartum - Leg Swelling and Edema - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1435 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Postpartum leg swelling assessment, generalized from the same NHS.UK C-section recovery blood-clot warning sign as Postpartum - Leg Pain.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] How many days/weeks since delivery?
2. [YES_NO] Is one leg more swollen than the other?
3. [YES_NO] Any shortness of breath or chest pain?
4. [YES_NO] If the patient is under 18, can they speak privately now, and do they say they feel safe with the accompanying adult?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Disposition level 100

Is a high blood-pressure reading with headache or vision change the primary concern?

Postpartum high blood pressure with headache or vision change remains a direct Qatar 999 emergency and must not redirect to an adult-only general blood-pressure protocol.

1. Disposition level 100

Is one leg more swollen or painful than the other, along with shortness of breath or chest pain?

One-sided leg swelling with breathing/chest symptoms is a recognized blood clot red flag, and the postpartum period carries an elevated clotting risk regardless of delivery method.

1. Disposition level 70

Is one leg noticeably more swollen than the other, without breathing or chest symptoms?

Asymmetric leg swelling should be checked promptly to rule out a blood clot, given the elevated postpartum risk.

1. Disposition level 15

Is this mild, even swelling in both legs/ankles with none of the features above?

Mild, symmetric ankle/leg swelling is common after birth from fluid shifts and is usually not a clot concern.

Advice

Emergency postpartum blood clot precautions

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now. Keep the patient at rest and do not let them drive. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: worsening breathing difficulty; chest pain develops.

Urgent postpartum leg swelling review

- Arrange prompt in-person assessment to rule out a blood clot; the exact non-emergency Qatar destination remains GOVERNANCE_REQUIRED.
- Call Back If: breathing difficulty or chest pain develops; swelling worsens.

Home care for mild postpartum leg swelling

- Elevate the legs when resting, stay mobile with gentle walking, and drink plenty of fluids.
- Call Back If: one leg becomes more swollen than the other; breathing difficulty develops.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 now. Keep the patient at rest and do not let them drive. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Caesarean section - Recovery" (blood clot warning sign), <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/caesarean-section/recovery/> (page last reviewed 04 January 2023) - generalized to all postpartum deliveries

Provenance

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